

2, What Is Printed on a Banknote Is the Vision of an Entire Nation

The first discovery that completely fascinated me was the profound indicative nature of the figures portrayed on a nation's official currency.

Oddly enough, I have personally never actually been abroad. My only experience outside the country was briefly stepping across the border into Vietnam from Chongzuo (崇左). Therefore, I genuinely possessed very little knowledge about the currencies of other nations.

It wasn't until a few days ago, when I browsed an illustrated encyclopedia of world currencies online, that I vividly felt something astonishing: **one can categorize the nations of the world into two diametrically opposed camps based solely on the identities of the figures on their banknotes!**

The first camp of nations always strives to highlight scholars who have made outstanding contributions to science, culture, arts, and social thought in their history. Their currencies commemorate the causes of those who expanded the frontiers of human cognition and pursued freedom, equality, and human liberation.

The currencies of the second camp of nations, however, are plastered with monarchs and "supreme leaders." The regimes of these nations glorify those "great men" (伟人) who temporarily crushed people's independent thoughts using coercive power, singing praises to a society of absolute conformity and militaristic obedience (令行禁止和整齐划一).

Because my personal knowledge of various parts of the world is admittedly shallow, I will not list exactly which countries belong to the former and which to the latter. I trust that anyone able to read these words is far clearer on this than I am.

Judging by factual performance, the former category often comprises developed democratic nations, whereas the latter invariably consists of oligarchies, bureaucracies, or outright hereditary dictatorships wearing the hypocritical cloak of democracy.

The former has generated almost all the scientific discoveries and technological advancements of the past five centuries, guiding the forward direction of culture, art, and social thought. The latter, conversely, constantly attempts to borrow imported science and technology solely to consolidate their own despotic rule, while harboring deep-seated hostility and terror toward advanced culture, art, and ideology.

This divergence in the selection of figures on currencies is both the cause and the result of their diametrically opposed historical achievements.

When a society universally believes that **social efficiency** (社会效率) should be prioritized over **political efficiency**—that a society desperately needs people who drive it forward rather than those who whip and herd it—this nation will naturally seek, select, and implement a sound social system. This, in turn, enables the entire nation to reap far more civilizational achievements.

The second type of society blindly worships "great men." This is not to say that there are no individuals within humanity who have achieved monumental feats. However, I maintain the belief that while a *cause* or an *enterprise* can be called "great," we should absolutely refrain from applying such a term to a *person*.

Because the greater a "hero" is elevated, the more insignificant and wretched the rest of the commoners become.

This has been proven countless times in the histories of these nations, particularly in the history of our own country! We can certainly discuss whether historical event A or event B contributed more significantly to human progress. But the moment one attempts to compare the absolute value of two human lives and pass judgment, it becomes incredibly dangerous—because such behavior effortlessly metastasizes into a total contempt for fundamental human rights.

My critique and satire of nations that print "great men" on their banknotes does not deny that politicians can also qualify as heroes. Indeed, one can easily notice that several figures on US dollar bills naturally hold the identity of politicians.

But these politicians who truly deserve to be called heroes are, without exception, individuals who valued **social efficiency** (社会效率) far above **political efficiency** (政治效率). They were people who liberated both the bodies and minds of the populace, rather than those who flaunted their power by manipulating the commoners. They were builders of society, not mere conquerors; they were men capable of restraining themselves, rather than those whose only skill was controlling others.

Pure political victory does not bring social progress, and merely defeating an enemy militarily cannot be counted as true martial virtue (武功). **The true monuments of merit are economic, institutional, and ideological legacies.**

Those autocrats who blatantly throw history into reverse simply because they are adept at waging war are nothing more than what the Chinese language calls "**thieves who steal the state**" (窃国之贼)!

I cannot help but think of the former currencies of Germany, Italy, and Japan: the Mark bearing the portrait of Kaiser Wilhelm I; the Lira coin engraved with the fascist *fascies* (束棒); the Japanese Yen depicting the *Hakko Ichiu* (八紘一宇 / "All Eight Corners of the World Under One Roof") monument.

Back when these three nations—now world-class developed countries—were completely off the righteous path, how strikingly similar was the social consciousness reflected on their currencies to that of the "second camp" nations still lingering today! Yet, from the end of World War II to the present, one can clearly witness the profound introspection of the former Axis powers just by observing the changes in their currency figureheads. Even within the international system established post-WWII, these three nations have successfully transformed into respected members of the global community.

The mighty tide of the world surges ceaselessly forward. Humanity will never stagnate forever due to the sabotage of a few ambitious demagogues, nor can coercive power eternally suppress the truth.

Within the short span of just a year and a half leading up to the end of 2024, we have already witnessed the universal failures of the "second camp" nations (*referring here to their regimes*). Some have already ceased to exist, while others have entered their death countdowns—this includes Bangladesh, Venezuela, Russia, Iran, and Syria.

There are also a few among them attempting to inch closer to civilization, such as Vietnam. I have heard that they have already implemented drastic reforms to their household registration (Hukou / 户籍) system. I sincerely hope that when the Vietnamese people look back on this step years from

now, they can proudly declare it an enterprise no less magnificent than Lê Lợi pacifying the Ming (黎利平吴)!

Observing global currencies did not necessarily bring me any brand-new knowledge; after all, I was already fully cognizant of the underlying mechanisms dictating the rise and fall of nations. What truly amazed me was how the massive disparities in the developmental stages of states and societies permeate every conceivable aspect of daily life so pervasively. Indeed, upon careful observation, we realize this difference is practically omnipresent.

Even on a tiny slip of paper currency, what is printed is the profound vision (见识) of an entire nation!

But why are the Chinese commoners entirely oblivious to this? After all, it was only through repeated observation, comparison, and massive reading that I managed to see it myself.

2，纸币上印的是整个国家的见识

第一个让我感到十分有趣的发现是一个国家官方货币上的人物身份具有的指示性。说来也怪，其实我本人一直都没有出过国，只有在崇左与越南的边境线上短暂跨出过国境，因此对于其他国家的货币的确是没有什么了解。直到前几天在网上看了一个各国货币的图鉴，我才如此鲜明地感受到原来仅凭货币上的人物之身份就可以把国家划分为两个截然不同的阵营，第一个阵营的国家的货币上总是想突出他们历史上对于科学、文化、艺术和社会思想做出杰出贡献的学者，纪念的是这些人开拓人类认知，追求自由、平等和人类解放的事业；而第二个国家的货币上则是君主和领袖们，这些国家的政权赞美那些用强权暂时压倒人们思想的“伟人”，歌颂令行禁止和整齐划一的社会。因为本人对于世界各地的了解实在短浅，也就不在这里列举前者包括哪些国家，后者又包括哪些国家，因为我想能够读到我写的文字的人一定比我更加清楚。

从事实的表现看来，前一类国家往往都是发达的民主国家，而后一类国家却往往披着民主的外衣大行寡头制，官僚制甚至干脆由某个家族世袭统治。前者创造了最近五个世纪以来几乎全部的科学发现和技术进步，引领了文化、艺术和社会思想前进的方向；而后者却总是试图借助舶来的科学技术以巩固自身的专制统治，对于先进的文化、艺术和思想，则敌视和恐惧。这两种国家在货币人物选取上的不同，既是他们功业相反的原因也是结果。当一个国家的社会普遍认为社会效率应当高于政治效率，社会更需要推动他进步的人而不是鞭笞他的人，这个国家自然就能够自己寻找、选择并实行良好的社会制度，这反过来也使整个国家取得了更多的文明成果。第二类社会迷信“伟人”，并不是说人类这个群体中不会有一些个体立下伟大的功勋，但是我仍然认为事业可以谈得上伟大，而对人则不应这么提。因为一个英雄多伟大，其余的百姓就有多卑微，这是这些国家的历史上，特别是我国的历史上被无数次证明的事。我们当然可以谈论事件 a 和事件 b 对于人类社会的进步哪个贡献更为显著，但是一旦将两个人生命的价值相互对比并作出判断则是十分危险的，因为这种行为很容易扩大到对于基本人权的蔑视。

我批评并讽刺那些将“伟人”印在纸币上的国家，并不是否认政治家也能够有资格被称为英雄，实际上人们很容易注意到美元纸币上的一些人物自然也有政治家的身份。但这些真正能被称为英雄的政治家无不是重视社会效率超过了政治效率的人，是使人们的身体和思想都被解放而不是靠操弄百姓来显示权力的人，是社会的建设者，而不只是征服者的人，能够约束自己而不是只会控制别人的人。单纯的政治胜利带不来社会进步，仅仅在军事上击败敌人也算不得武功，真正的勋业是经济，制度和思想遗产。那些仗着自己能征惯战便肆无忌惮地开历史倒车的独夫，不过是汉语中说的“窃国之贼”罢了。我不禁想到德国，意大利和日本曾经的货币，印着德皇威廉一世头像的马克，刻着法西斯标志“束棒”的里拉硬币，

描绘有“八纮一宇”塔的日元。当这三个如今已是世界一流发达国家没有在正道的时候，它们货币上所反映的社会意识与现在仍然残留的第二类国家有多大的相似性啊。可是从第二次世界大战之后到如今，人们确实从他们货币人物选择的变化看到了原轴心国家的反思，即使是在由二次大战之后确立的国际体系下，这三个国家也已经成为在全世界受到尊重的国际成员。

世界潮流浩浩荡荡，人类终不会因为少数野心家的破坏而停滞不前，强权也不可能永远压制真理，到2024年底短短一年半内我们已经看到了第二类国家（此处是指政权）普遍的失败，他们有的已经不复存在，有的已经陷入了死亡倒计时，这包括孟加拉国，委内瑞拉，俄罗斯，伊朗和叙利亚。他们中还有一些正在试着向文明靠拢，比如越南，我听说他们已经对于户籍制度进行了大刀阔斧的改革，衷心希望越南人民在若干年后回首这一步，能够豪迈地说它是不亚于黎利平吴的事业。观察各国货币对我来说倒也没有带来什么新的知识，毕竟在此前天下成败我已知悉，真正令我称奇的是，国家、社会之间所处阶段的巨大差异竟然会如此无孔不入的表现在生活的方方面面，其实当我们仔细观察之后就会意识到这种差别几乎无处不在了。即使是一张小小的纸币，印的却是整个民族的见识。可是为什么中国的老百姓就是意识不到这一点？我也是在反复地观察对比和阅读中才看到呢。